CHAPTER 2

New Language, New Syntax

The first look at a new language is a daunting task. Symbols look foreign, and you're trying to understand how everything fits together. It's the same for all languages, and Elixir is no different. But Elixir has a fairly small amount of syntax, which makes it relatively quick to learn.

Elixir has three distinct parts that you'll need to be comfortable with before you are ready to build applications. The first, and most basic, is the syntax of Elixir. Next is the process model and how to leverage OTP. And finally, you'll need to know about the common libraries that you'll use when you write applications. We'll cover all of these topics throughout this book, but this chapter focuses on Elixir's syntax.

The goal is that, by the end of Part I, you'll be able to read everyday Elixir code without fear, although you won't have yet put it together into an application. Don't worry, we'll write an application in Part II. You'll see comparisons made with Ruby along the way. This will help you more quickly turn your Ruby knowledge into Elixir experience.

In this chapter, we'll go over data types, operators, modules, and functions. You'll see how these things fit together to create the foundations of Elixir applications. And you'll see where danger can lurk in some of the syntaxes. But first, let's step back and take a look at some differences between Elixir and Ruby.

The Big Picture

On the surface, Ruby and Elixir code appear very similar to each other, but make no mistake, they are quite different. It's best to acknowledge their visual similarities, but don't dwell on it or get frustrated that things work differently between them.